The new structures would be tested on tour to Sri Lanka, and all went well. We won the ODI series 2–1, with Hash scoring a century in the first and second matches, and Quinton and me each scoring centuries as we won the decisive third match. Showing considerable skill, Hash led the Test team first to victory in Galle and then to a hard-fought draw in Colombo, and we celebrated a notable Test series win in Sri Lanka.

Our minds were starting to turn to the next World Cup, to be played in Australia and New Zealand at the start of 2015, and Cricket South Africa had planned a thorough and detailed eight-month programme to ensure we would be properly prepared.

We won an ODI series against Zimbabwe 3–0, and then won four out of five matches in a triangular series with the Zimbabweans and Australia, eventually beating the Aussies in the final.

Next we flew west for a virtual dress rehearsal: travelling to play in the host countries of the World Cup, trying to become familiar with hotels, training facilities and venues. We played three ODIs in New Zealand, winning the series 2–0 with one rained off, and then played three T20s and five ODIs in Australia.

We were performing well and victory in the opening T20 international against Australia in Adelaide meant we had won no fewer than 11 of our last 13 limited-overs internationals. Morale was high, and we seemed to be getting into the extremely useful habit of winning. Then, almost overnight, our form suddenly dipped and we lost six of the next seven matches against the increasingly confident and chipper Australians.

Some commentators began to scoff at our unprecedented preparations, but I was not especially concerned. It would have been better if we were winning, but we were making mistakes and learning; we knew we would have to field well and we knew we could not afford to give away too many extras.

Lastly, a very significant silver lining to the dark cloud was that the run of defeats significantly reduced the level of expectation back home and that, we decided, was a positive development.